the bat therefore takes a hammering – the bottom left of my bat always cracks and bombs out first.

But G&M really make phenomenal bats, and I'm not just saying that because they're one of my sponsors. They've just made me my 101st bat – every bat gets numbered – and they're so well made that I can hardly tell the difference between any of the six bats I usually have with me on tour.

… and my cricket

And that's a perfect lead-up to discussing my approach to cricket. As I said in the intro to this chapter, there's not a whole lot of difference between the way I've lived my life and the way I've played my cricket. On the field, the spontaneity of my personality has been bolstered by quick-firing synapses and above-average reflexes and coordination. It means I don't have to think myself into that 'zone' that sports psychologists are always talking about.

A lot of athletes are very analytical in their approach. They do a lot of planning, preparation and strategising before they compete, but I believe this can have a negative effect on their performance. Sports psychologists consequently make a lot of money coaching athletes to just let go and let their natural talent and ability take over. It's only then that goals are scored, passing shots are nailed and runs flow off the bat. It's easy for me, though. As I have never consciously thought about having to back my physical skills with a sound mental approach, I have never had to unhook the analytical part of my brain before I go out to play. I've always just done it. It's the only way I know.

In order for me to play to the best of my ability, I have to play my natural game. And my natural game is to go out and look for runs. For example, in my entire cricket career I've always played the pull shot against short-pitched bowling. It's an instinctive skill. Some batsmen simply have the ability to pick up length a lot quicker than other batters, and these are the guys who basically pull really well. If they see a bowler throw in a ball that's way too short, they just get underneath and hit it.

When I try to play defensively, by leaving the ball, for example, I inevitably end up in two minds about what to do next. And let me tell you, there's no time for second thoughts when the ball's coming at you at 150 km/h, boet. Steve Waugh, for instance, had worked out that trying to hook and pull would often cost him his wicket, and once he'd eliminated that shot from his repertoire, his average steadily increased. Waugh dropped